# The East Oakland Compost Center

## Es 155: The Built Environment


## By Bella Kormos

**Abstract:** The East Oakland Compost Center (EOCC) is a community based initiative to help address social inequity, food insecurity, and community wellness through composting and local empowerment. East Oakland has a beautiful vibrant cultural community, but it is also marked by racial segregation, violence, and systemic poverty. The EOCC will collect food waste from East Oakland residents and turn it into nutrient-rich soil for East Oakland Residents. This compost center is more than just soil, it is also about bringing the community together through community events, yoga, and workshops on composting and gardening. This promotes long-term wellness, resilience, and sustainability and resists green gentrification through promoting culturally rooted outreach and local empowerment. Soil becomes a tool for healing, self-determination, and environmental justice.

## I. Background

Oakland is a city with approximately 433,544 residents located in the San Francisco Bay Area. In 2019, it was found that Oakland was in the "92nd percentile of segregation and compared to all other U.S. cities with populations over 200,000, Oakland ranked 14th most segregated," (Orenstein). Historically racist housing policies redlined certain neighborhoods, and created significant racial disparities in which the impacts are still massively impacting neighborhoods including a lack of access to healthy food, resources, and opportunities. Food justice can be defined as, "the struggle against racism, exploitation, and oppression taking place within the food system that addresses inequalities root causes both within and beyond the food chain," (Hope and Cadji 108). The difference in access to grocery stores in east Oakland in comparison to the oakland hills is stark. For instance, there are less than 3 grocery stores in the deep east Oakland , but over 30 liquor stores, while in North Oakland's 94611 zip code there are more than 4 supermarkets and less than 20 liquor stores. It is significantly easier to drink alcohol than eat sustainable food in east Oakland. Today's efforts for addressing food insecurity and justice are centered around, "alternative food systems, like local, slow, organic and create opportunities for grassroots economic development by providing jobs for low-income people of color in the alternative food sector," (Hope and Cadji 109). However, local programs and food justice organizations like farmers markets, community gardens, and upscale health stores that attempt to serve long-term low-income communities of color often appeal to new, more affluent residents, signal to developers and other urban boosters, and cause green gentrification. Food plays a large role in the vitality and health of a community. About 14% of Oakland residents are living below the poverty line, and since ownership of cars in this demographic is low, many residents have very little access to larger grocery stores. Overall mental and physical health is a major issue in East Oakland because of a lack of ownership, healthy food, and resources, and these issues need attention, and need to be analyzed with a

new point of view to limit displacement and boosterism. The East Oakland Compost Center will take soil, and create empowerment, justice, and improved wellness in these communities.

## II. Proposed Solution:

The East Oakland Compost Center collects organic waste from residents, schools, and local businesses to convert into nutrient-rich soil. This soil will be locally sourced, and locally distributed specifically for east oakland zip-codes. The way it works is residents of these specific zip-codes: 94601, 94603, 94605, 94621 will qualify to be a part of the EOCC for free. Residents will bring their weekly food scraps to a center, as there will be one at every already existing community garden, and within a 5 minute walk of each zip code. Then, the scraps will be picked up and brought to our warehouse, and the compost will turn into nutrient rich soil. At the center, there will also be a recreational team planning and organizing monthly free community cooking classes, classes on composting, and classes on renewable energy and sustainability. When the residents come to the classes, they can also pick up fresh soil and free houseplants, greening the community from inside out. The soil can be used for the houseplants, but also is encouraged to be used for at-home gardening if residents have the opportunity to do so. Along with the soil being distributed to the community members, it will also be distributed to local farms to subsidize and help fund locally owned and locally operated food co-ops like the the DEEP food co-op, which pairs with urban farmers and community gardens to bring organic food conveniently located in deep east Oakland. This project is largely inspired by the Isla Vista Compost Collective, which started as a UCSB ELI project, and has flourished into a food waste to healthy soil well-oiled machine.

The first resilience criteria that this project addresses is mental and physical wellness, and an increase in the quality of life. Simply bringing the community together is known to enhance mental and physical health. Additionally, studies show that simply having more houseplants and greenery in your house increases happiness, focus, and overall well being. People spend approximately 80-90% of their

time indoors, so indoor plants are incredibly vital to understanding environmental exposure and health, (Zhao 2023). People spend 80–90% of their time indoors (Klepeis et al., 2001; Wang et al., 2008; World Health Organization, 2014); therefore, indoor plants could be more critical than outdoor greenery to understand the interaction between environmental exposure and health. In this study, it was hypothesized that photosynthesis, transpiration, purification, "exhibit direct impacts, including generating oxygen, increasing humidity and decreasing temperature, and reducing air pollutants, which could all eventually influence mental health," (Zhao 2023). In addition to mental health, this project also encourages at-home and community gardening. Gardening is a, "type of exercise preferable to others because they were producing something at the same time and not just exercising for its own sake. Gardening activities require different types of exercise such as fine motor skills when cutting flowers or harvesting food to highly aerobic activities[...]reducing the risk of many diseases including heart disease and diabetes," (Berret 2018).

The second criteria that I will focus on is self-reliance. With increased access to soil, gardening, education, and healthy food from local co-ops, food insecurity will decrease and overall resilience will increase. Additionally, the conversion of food waste to compost reduces methane emissions into the atmosphere. Unfortunately, "Decomposition of organic waste under anaerobic conditions in solid waste disposal sites leads to the formation of biogas consisting of approximately 50% methane[...]and among the anthropogenic emissions it is the second largest contributor to global warming after CO2," (IGES White Paper 2008). Compost mitigates local environmental hazards, and creates a more sustainable circular economy and self reliance in east oakland.

Bringing local organizations together is also a major component of this compost center. This brings us to the next resilience criteria, ownership and equity. I hope to partner with Food Co-ops like DEEP food co-op, and education programs like FoodWhat?! These local programs are run by east-oakland residents for east oakland residents, similar to the Compost Center. Having economic

support through the distribution of our soil enhances these local businesses and allows stronger local ownership. Additionally, Daniel Lerch, writes,

> In communities, identity can really only be determined by the community's members[...] it is important to ensure that decisions are in harmony with the identity that the community actually desires for itself. One way to do so is to prioritize public participation in urban planning processes, such as by holding community workshops and visioning sessions and providing opportunities for residents, businesses, and other stakeholders to contribute to planning and design in meaningful ways, (Lerch 2017).

Empowering local community voices will be a major proponent of how the Compost Center evolves, and how it contributes to equity, ownership, and overall resilience of East Oakland. This project is intentionally designed to avoid green gentrification. In class, green gentrification and the green paradox was defined as well-meaning environmental initiatives inadvertently displacing or harming the communities they aim to help, (Anguelovski and Connolly 2022). Greening alone cannot alone achieve justice.

Once the center is established and running, I hope that the collective can scale up to more directly tackling food insecurity. This includes bringing soil to urban agriculture and local farming, subsidizing money to local farmers so that farmers markets can be affordable and accessible to east oakland residents, and the conversion of compost to biofuel and local renewable energy sources. This project begins with soil providing community building, wellness, and a general reeducation on what healthy food is, and can hopefully become an inspiration for a much more circular, sustainable, equitable, and self-reliant East Oakland.

**Project Activity:** What is the timeline of your proposed project? When do you believe it needs to be completed? How, specifically, will the plan be carried out? List and describe all tasks and action items involved to successfully implement this plan. Be as specific as possible.

The East Oakland Compost Center will develop in about a year, with full implementation of infrastructure and community engagement by the end of the time frame. I have organized this project in 4 phases, and with an outreach and advertisement strategy. The first six months will be mostly relationship and community building, and infrastructure building, and then next six months will be dedicated to evaluation and refinement. The project will begin at the start of the growing season (spring 2026) in order to maximize the distribution of compost, coordinate with community gardens and partners, and maximize impact.

**Phase 1: Planning and Partnership Building (Months 1-2)**

First off, I will interview all stakeholders (below) and take notes on their input, make changes based on feedback. Then, I will identify sites working with the Oakland City government and community groups to identify compost drop off/pick up locations near existing community gardens in zip codes: 94601, 94603, 94605, and 94621. Next, I will hire a team of local, passionate local youth and residents to operate compost logistics and run educational workshops. I will also create programs and curriculums for the following free classes: Cooking classes, How to compost?, How to take care of Houseplants? Mental Wellness, Trauma-informed yoga by volunteer yoga instructors, Climate Change Awareness.

**Phase 2: Infrastructure Development and Pilot (Months 3-5)**

I will need to first find a warehouse and set it up as a small centralized composting facility for processing food waste into soil. Then, I will install the compost bins at each drop-off site with signage in English and spanish. Begin  with a small group of 50-100 households. Community Workshops begin with monthly events on composting, indoor gardening, food justice, and soil and houseplant giveaways.

**Phase 3: Expansion and Soil Distribution (Months 6-9)**

In phase 3, I will scale up the collection by opening participation to all qualifying residents of East Oakland. Me and the team will distribute the compost to local farms, food co-ops like the DEEP, and

residents. I will also plan block parties and seasonal neighborhood gatherings to build awareness and community.

**Phase 4: Evaluation, Adjustment (months 10-12)**

Lastly, I will survey the residents and stakeholders for feedback on mental/physical health, food access, and soil use. I will adjust operations in any way I need to, modifying drop-off hours or educational content. I will next develop a roadmap to expand the EEOC to integrate small-scale biofuel production for reliable community renewable energy sources.

## III. Stakeholders:

First I will interview **5 local residents,** who are the more vital stakeholders because they are both the contributors (bringing in the food waste) and the beneficiaries. Hearing their story with food injustice, environmental neglect, and displacement will shape this project. The next stakeholder is the **owners of community gardens** and **potential volunteers.** One existing community garden includes Tassafaronga Park Garden, 81st Ave Urban Farm which will support the compost collective in many ways. They will help shape programming and ensure that the EEOC complements existing efforts. Additionally, **the owners of local food co-ops** and **local farmers** will be interviewed as well since these groups will provide input on soil quality, compost techniques, and help redistribute the soil to support urban agriculture. **Scientists and soil experts** will also help maintain the health and safety of composted soil. Experts including faculty from UC Berkeley or community science organizations with knowledge in waste decomposition and urban ecology. Additionally, the **Oakland city government** must coordinate with the EOCC to align management regulations, land use zoning, and environmental permitting. I also really want to discuss and plan this project along with the local Ohlone tribe and cultural knowledge keepers. This project must respect and honor indigenous knowledge, food systems, and the relationship to the land, and collaboration may include sharing traditional composting and supporting cultural healing. Also, local artists and cultural workers will play a unique role. In many

cases, the green gentrification of communities occurs when the wrong kind of social media advertisement is utilized. To combat gentrification and bring local artists' work to light, I will hire some artists to design art pieces and posters to be put around the community to raise awareness for this project.

## IV. Potential Challenges and Next Steps

I envision the biggest challenge facing this project is ensuring consistent community participation. In communities with a lot of single-parent homes, facing systemic poverty, housing insecurity, violence, and over-policing, environmental projects may not seem like a high priority. To address this, the EOCC will be framed as a resource–a free, low-barrier opportunity for healing, rest, empowerment, and free plants! Working with local artists, this project will highlight Oakland cultural identities, and be advertised in unique ways. Connecting wellness and resistance is also a major part of this project; the Compost Center is self-care and community care– “rest is resistance”. So, to ensure active participation there will be a free babysitting area for families, there will be free food to incentivize people to join, and there will be a hired team of locals that will spread the word and bring friends along. Hiring and training residents as ambassadors to spread awareness through personal networks, church groups, schools, and corner stores–trusted places of community connection. To make this project viable, the first steps include securing a warehouse, mapping out drop-off locations, and interviewing the local stakeholders to help refine this plan. I believe that deeply embedding EOCC in local culture and treating participation as joy, wellness, and empowerment will allow this project to grow into a long-lasting collaborative effort to evolve community needs.

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**Artistic proof of concept:**

For this project, I decided to create a poster for a community educational composting event with watercolor. For my project, I hope to actually work with local artists to empower the diverse culture that Oakland nurtures. However, for the creative component of this project, I decided to create my own personal art to outline the unique and creative approach that I want this project to take in terms of advertisement. This art project took me a few days because I am not the most artistically inclined, but I put a good amount of time, passion, and effort into it.

FREE cooking CLASS
east oakland
COMPOST CENTER
Drop off food waste, pick up some soil, take a community class!
REST IS RESISTENCE

HOW TO compost
free community class
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